

FADE IN:

EXT. NEVADA DESERT - DAY

Dead quiet as the sun creeps over the horizon.

Two rabbits scurry along. Stop and start. Scan for predators.

Whisk ahead, stop again. Sniff the ground. Dirt shifts. They zip away as a human hand twitches.

ARTHUR LANCASTER, 60s, sits up, tries to get his bearings. Stares blankly - *what happened?*

His face bruised and swollen, he winces as he rises. Dusts the dirt from his clothes, notes he's covered in dried blood. A quick inspection - *he's not wounded, it's not his blood?*

He glances around but everything looks the same, so he picks a direction and labors away.

EXT. DESERTED NEIGHBORHOOD - DAY

Arthur stumbles upon a street that meets the desert. Half-built houses sit next to weed strewn lots.

He tries a water spigot on the only completed home. No luck.

Trudges on as the sun beats down on him.

EXT. CITY STREET - DAY

The deserted neighborhood gives way to a city street.

Traffic sounds. Cars whiz by Arthur. A gas station sits across the street, he heads to it.

INT. CITY BUS - DAY

JIM O'BOYLE, 30s, bus driver, sees Arthur step off the curb.

He lays on his horn. His passengers perk up at the blare.

STREET

Arthur hears nothing, continues forward.

BUS

Jim slams on his brakes. The bus slows but doesn't stop.

JIM
Come on. Come on!

Jim pumps the brakes several times. They catch and squeal.
The passengers rock front and back.

The bus grinds to a halt a foot from Arthur.

EXT. CITY BUS - CONTINUOUS

Jim jumps onto the street.

JIM
What the hell?!

Arthur continues forward as if nothing happened.

JIM (CONT'D)
You're gonna get yourself killed!

Jim grabs Arthur, shakes him.

JIM (CONT'D)
What's wrong with you?

Arthur sways. Jim catches him, lowers Arthur onto the curb.
Looks back at his bus. Riders stare at him from their
windows. A woman talks on her phone.

JIM (CONT'D)
(to the woman)
Call 911!

A man videos Jim and Arthur on his phone from the doorway.

JIM (CONT'D)
(to the man)
You! Grab the water from my seat.

The man turns back into the bus.

JIM (CONT'D)
(to the woman)
They coming?

The woman nods. The man holds out the water bottle.

JIM (CONT'D)
Thanks.
(to Arthur)
What's your name?

Arthur stares back blankly.

JIM (CONT'D)

Do you know where you are?

Nothing from Arthur.

JIM (CONT'D)

Here.

Arthur takes it, drinks hastily.

JIM (CONT'D)

That's better.

(to the passengers)

Sorry for the inconvenience, folks.

Jim pulls his phone from his pocket. Dials.

Arthur finishes the bottle. Relaxes slightly. Some light comes back into his eyes.

JIM (CONT'D)

Ed, Jim here. I'm need a second bus at... no, almost hit a guy. We already called 911.

Arthur perks up when he hears "Ed." A hint of recognition.

JIM (O.S.) (CONT'D)

I think he's okay.

(listens)

Pretty sure, but needs a doctor.

Arthur tries to speak but it's more of a croak.

ARTHUR

Eddie?

JIM

(into phone)

Hold on.

(to Arthur)

What? That's you?

ARTHUR

Eddie!

Arthur tries to rise up. Jim stops him.

JIM

You Eddie? Sit, help's on the way.

(into the phone)

Ed, listen. Just send a bus and get my passengers on their way.

ARTHUR
(quietly)
Eddie.

INT. APARTMENT - DAY

A single man's apartment. Nothing on the walls, no knickknacks or decorations.

SUPER: SIX DAYS EARLIER

Everything crisp and in place. Like a model home without the warmth. So perfect that if you didn't know better, you'd think no one lives here.

BATHROOM

Arthur methodically brushes, rinses. Checks his teeth, then his appearance.

With short, conservative hair, he'd be at home in any boardroom across the country.

Rather gaunt and with a certain sadness in his eyes, it's like something has been eating away at him for some time.

CLOSET

Pulls the first of many identical white polos from a hanger.

Does the same with a pair of khakis.

Steps into black sneakers.

BEDROOM

Puts on a plain watch. Places his wallet in his pocket.

Clips a small case with a pocket stun gun onto his plain black belt.

Picks up his keys and a thick brown envelope.

HALLWAY

Lifts a picture from a table. Stares at it. Shuts his eyes.

QUICK FLASH

A breathtakingly beautiful blond, 20s, smiles sweetly.

BACK TO SCENE

After a cleansing breath, he puts the picture back in place.

INT. HALLWAY - DAY

Locks his apartment door. Checks it twice.

Knocks on the apartment door across the hall.

INT. MRS. REED'S APARTMENT - DAY

A black cat greets Arthur. He rubs its ears.

ARTHUR
Morning Jasper.
(calls out)
Good morning Mrs. Reed.

MRS. REED (O.S.)
Good morning Arthur.

Arthur steps into the --

KITCHEN

Places a mug of water in the microwave.

Checks Jasper's food.

DING!

Adds a teabag to the steaming water.

LIVING ROOM

MRS. REED, 80s, in a wheelchair but still feisty, greets him.

MRS. REED (CONT'D)
You are too good to me. Let me look
at you.

Mrs. Reed takes the tea, inspects him.

MRS. REED (CONT'D)
Everyday. The same outfit. How're
you ever going to get a woman...

ARTHUR
I don't need one.

MRS. REED
...looking so cardboard?